Weeknight pasta and rice dishes

For a fast dinner, cook the pasta in well-salted water and save a cup of the cooking water. Toss the drained pasta with garlic softened in olive oil, a handful of cherry tomatoes and basil, and loosen the sauce with a splash of the starchy water.

For rice, rinse it until the water runs clear, then use one and a half cups of water for every cup of white rice. Bring to a boil, cover, turn the heat to low for 15 minutes, and let it rest off the heat for 5 minutes before fluffing.

Leftover rice makes the best fried rice. Cook it hot in a wide pan with a little oil, an egg, frozen peas and soy sauce.